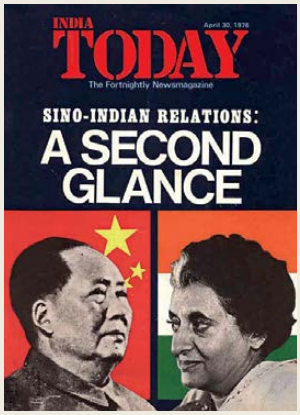
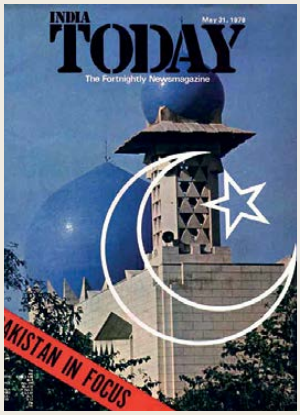
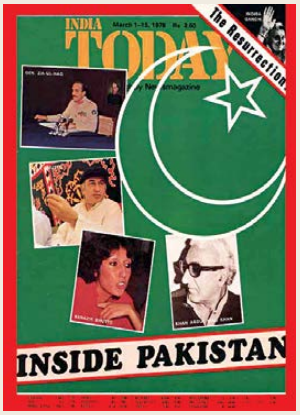


▲ Apr. 30, 1976



▲ May 31, 1978



▲ Mar. 15, 1978

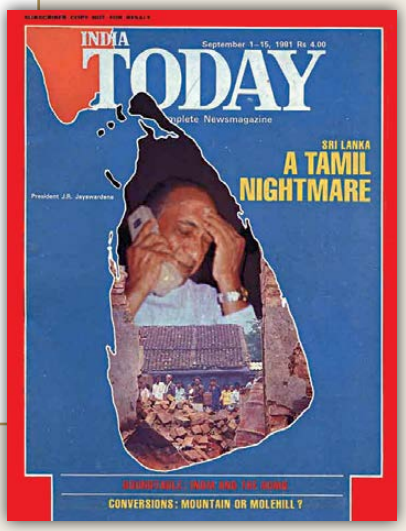


▲ Apr. 30, 1981

| GLOBAL EYE | 1975-1985 |

TROUBLES ABROAD

In its first decade, INDIA TODAY followed the gathering clouds in the region: Islamisation under Zia in Pakistan and the start of the civil war in Sri Lanka



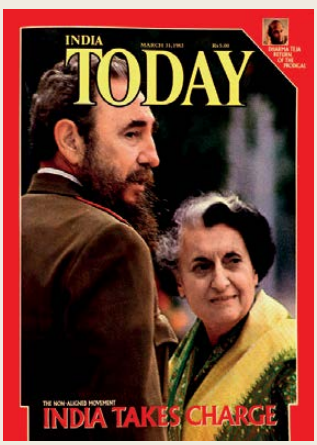
Sept. 15, 1981 ▶

In **the decade under review, the world drifted into a harder phase.** The Cold War still framed global politics, and its effects were felt through internal upheavals, military takeovers and the erosion of democratic space in fragile states. India, however, stuck to its traditional non-aligned path in foreign policy and in March 1983 hosted the seventh NAM (Non-Aligned Movement) summit.

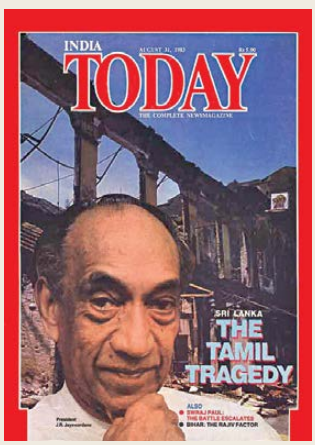
In Pakistan, General Zia-ul-Haq emerged not just as a military ruler but as an architect of long-term transformation. Civilian institutions weakened as authority concentrated in uniformed hands. Law, politics and religion were fused into a new governing logic that reshaped society itself. Islamisation altered courts, education and public behaviour, embedding ideology into the state's functioning. It was a remaking of the republic, one that would outlast Zia's rule and influence regional stability.

In Sri Lanka, the failure of accommodation turned ethnic tension into open violence. Long-standing grievances between the Sinhalese majority and the Tamil minority—over language, jobs and political power, began spilling onto the streets. By the early 1980s, communal clashes escalated into mass bloodshed. Homes were burned, lives lost and trust shattered. What began as sporadic unrest soon carried the seeds of prolonged civil war. The violence revealed how quickly plural societies could fracture when politics hardened identities instead of managing them.

These events were early expressions of the tensions that would dominate sub-continental politics in the decades that followed. ■



▲ Mar. 31, 1983



▲ Aug. 31, 1983